

COUPLES COMMUNICATION WORKBOOK

Build Deeper Connection Through Better Communication

Active Listening | Conflict Resolution | Deep Connection

By Daniel Tesfamariam

Research-based tools, exercises, and scripts for couples who
want to communicate more effectively and love more deeply.

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This workbook is for educational purposes. For serious relationship
concerns, please seek guidance from a licensed couples therapist.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Chapter 1: Communication Foundations	3
Chapter 2: Active Listening Skills	11
Chapter 3: Conflict Resolution Tools	19
Chapter 4: Deep Connection Exercises	31
Chapter 5: Hard Conversations Scripts	41
Chapter 6: Weekly & Monthly Rituals	51
Chapter 7: Date Night Planning	59
Chapter 8: Rebuilding Trust	67
Final: Next Steps	75

CHAPTER 1: COMMUNICATION FOUNDATIONS

Why Communication is the Foundation of Love

Research by Dr. John Gottman, who studied thousands of couples over four decades, shows that the number one predictor of relationship success or failure is the quality of communication between partners. It is not compatibility, shared interests, or even love alone that keeps couples together. It is the ability to communicate needs, resolve conflicts, and maintain emotional connection through conversation.

The good news is that communication is a skill, not a talent. No one is born a great communicator. These skills can be learned, practiced, and improved at any stage of a relationship, whether you have been together 6 months or 30 years.

The Four Horsemen of Relationship Destruction

Dr. Gottman identified four communication patterns that predict divorce with over 90% accuracy. Recognizing these in yourself is the first step to changing them:

1. Criticism (Attacking your partner's character)

Criticism is different from a complaint. A complaint addresses a specific behavior.

Criticism attacks who your partner IS as a person.

Criticism example: You never help around the house. You are so lazy and selfish.

Healthy alternative: I felt overwhelmed with housework this week. Could we talk about dividing chores more evenly?

2. Contempt (Superiority, disgust, disrespect)

Contempt is the single greatest predictor of divorce. It includes eye-rolling, sarcasm, name-calling, mocking, and hostile humor. It communicates: I am better than you.

Contempt example: Oh, you forgot to pay the bill AGAIN? I should not be surprised.

Healthy alternative: I noticed the bill was missed. Can we set up autopay so we do not have to worry about it?

3. Defensiveness (Refusing responsibility)

Defensiveness is a way of blaming your partner. It says: The problem is not me, it is you. It prevents resolution because no one takes ownership.

Defensive example: It is not MY fault we were late. YOU took forever getting ready.

Healthy alternative: You are right, I should have started getting ready earlier. I will set an alarm next time.

4. Stonewalling (Shutting down, withdrawing)

Stonewalling happens when one partner completely withdraws from interaction. They may physically leave, go silent, or appear to be listening but are actually checked out.

Stonewall example: Partner crosses arms, avoids eye contact, gives one-word answers or silence.

Healthy alternative: I am feeling flooded right now. Can we take a 20-minute break and come back to this when I am calmer?

Communication Style Assessment

Each partner should complete this separately, then compare and discuss:

Partner 1: _____

Rate yourself honestly (1=Never, 5=Often):

- ___ I criticize my partner's character rather than addressing specific behaviors
- ___ I use sarcasm, eye-rolling, or contemptuous language
- ___ I get defensive instead of taking responsibility
- ___ I shut down or withdraw during difficult conversations
- ___ I interrupt my partner when they are speaking
- ___ I bring up past grievances during current arguments
- ___ I assume I know what my partner is thinking or feeling
- ___ I raise my voice or use aggressive body language
- ___ I avoid difficult conversations altogether
- ___ I use I feel statements when expressing needs

Total: ___ / 50

Partner 2: _____

Rate yourself honestly (1=Never, 5=Often):

- ___ I criticize my partner's character rather than addressing specific behaviors
- ___ I use sarcasm, eye-rolling, or contemptuous language
- ___ I get defensive instead of taking responsibility
- ___ I shut down or withdraw during difficult conversations
- ___ I interrupt my partner when they are speaking
- ___ I bring up past grievances during current arguments
- ___ I assume I know what my partner is thinking or feeling
- ___ I raise my voice or use aggressive body language
- ___ I avoid difficult conversations altogether
- ___ I use I feel statements when expressing needs

Total: ___ / 50

Our Communication Goals

What we want to improve about our communication:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

How we will practice (frequency and setting):

YOUR ACTION ITEMS - Chapter 1

- ☐ Both partners complete the communication style assessment
- ☐ Compare results together without judgment
- ☐ Identify which of the Four Horsemen you each tend toward
- ☐ Set 3 specific communication goals as a couple
- ☐ Commit to weekly practice using this workbook
- ☐ Establish a safe word for when conversations get heated

CHAPTER 2: ACTIVE LISTENING SKILLS

The Art of Truly Hearing Your Partner

Most people listen to respond rather than listening to understand. Active listening is a deliberate practice where you give your full attention to your partner, seek to understand their perspective completely, and communicate that understanding back to them before sharing your own thoughts.

When your partner feels truly heard, they feel safe, valued, and connected. Most arguments escalate not because of the issue itself, but because one or both partners do not feel heard.

The HEAR Method

- H - Halt: Stop what you are doing. Put down your phone. Turn toward your partner.
- E - Empathize: Try to understand their feelings, not just their words.
- A - Acknowledge: Reflect back what you heard to confirm understanding.
- R - Respond: Only after they confirm you understood, share your perspective.

Active Listening Practice Scenarios

Take turns being the speaker and the listener for each scenario. The speaker shares for 3 minutes uninterrupted. The listener practices the HEAR method.

Scenario 1

Speaker: Share about something stressful at work this week. Listener: Practice reflecting back what you hear without offering solutions.

Speaker's notes: _____

Listener's reflection (what I heard): _____

Speaker: Did the listener get it right? ☐ Yes ☐ Partially ☐ No

What we learned from this exercise: _____

Scenario 2

Speaker: Describe a childhood memory that shaped who you are today. Listener: Ask follow-up questions that show curiosity about their experience.

Speaker's notes: _____

Listener's reflection (what I heard): _____

Speaker: Did the listener get it right? ☐ Yes ☐ Partially ☐ No

What we learned from this exercise: _____

Scenario 3

Speaker: Share something you appreciate about your partner that you rarely say out loud.

Listener: Receive the compliment fully without deflecting.

Speaker's notes: _____

Listener's reflection (what I heard): _____

Speaker: Did the listener get it right? ☐ Yes ☐ Partially ☐ No

What we learned from this exercise: _____

Scenario 4

Speaker: Talk about a fear or worry you have been carrying. Listener: Validate their feelings without trying to fix or minimize.

Speaker's notes: _____

Listener's reflection (what I heard): _____

Speaker: Did the listener get it right? ☐ Yes ☐ Partially ☐ No

What we learned from this exercise: _____

Scenario 5

Speaker: Describe your ideal weekend together in detail. Listener: Notice how their vision might differ from yours without judgment.

Speaker's notes: _____

Listener's reflection (what I heard): _____

Speaker: Did the listener get it right? ☐ Yes ☐ Partially ☐ No

What we learned from this exercise: _____

Scenario 6

Speaker: Share something small that has been bothering you recently. Listener: Practice hearing without becoming defensive.

Speaker's notes: _____

Listener's reflection (what I heard): _____

Speaker: Did the listener get it right? ☐ Yes ☐ Partially ☐ No

What we learned from this exercise: _____

Scenario 7

Speaker: Talk about a dream or goal you have for the next year. Listener: Ask questions that help them explore and expand their vision.

Speaker's notes: _____

Listener's reflection (what I heard): _____

Speaker: Did the listener get it right? ☐ Yes ☐ Partially ☐ No

What we learned from this exercise: _____

Scenario 8

Speaker: Describe how you felt during your last disagreement. Listener: Focus entirely on understanding their emotional experience.

Speaker's notes: _____

Listener's reflection (what I heard): _____

Speaker: Did the listener get it right? ☐ Yes ☐ Partially ☐ No

What we learned from this exercise: _____

Scenario 9

Speaker: Share what makes you feel most loved and connected. Listener: Take notes so you can remember and act on this information.

Speaker's notes: _____

Listener's reflection (what I heard): _____

Speaker: Did the listener get it right? ☐ Yes ☐ Partially ☐ No

What we learned from this exercise: _____

Scenario 10

Speaker: Talk about something you wish was different in your relationship. Listener: Stay curious and open without becoming defensive or hurt.

Speaker's notes: _____

Listener's reflection (what I heard): _____

Speaker: Did the listener get it right? ☐ Yes ☐ Partially ☐ No

What we learned from this exercise: _____

YOUR ACTION ITEMS - Chapter 2

-
- ☐ Practice the HEAR method during one conversation today
 - ☐ Complete at least 5 of the 10 scenarios this week
 - ☐ Notice when you are listening to respond vs. listening to understand
 - ☐ Put your phone away during all conversations with your partner
 - ☐ Ask your partner: Do you feel heard by me? What could I do better?

CHAPTER 3: CONFLICT RESOLUTION TOOLS

Healthy Conflict Is Normal and Necessary

All couples argue. Research shows that 69% of conflicts in relationships are perpetual, meaning they never fully resolve because they are rooted in fundamental personality differences or values. The goal is not to eliminate conflict but to manage it in a way that strengthens rather than damages your relationship.

Healthy conflict means both partners feel safe to express their needs, differences are discussed with respect, and resolutions (or compromises) are reached that both partners can live with.

The Softened Startup

How you begin a conversation about a problem determines 96% of whether it will end well. A harsh startup (criticism, blame, contempt) guarantees a negative outcome. A softened startup dramatically increases the chance of productive dialogue.

Formula for a Softened Startup:

I feel _____ (emotion, not accusation)
about _____ (specific situation, not character)
and I need _____ (positive need, not criticism)

Examples:

HARSH: You never help with the dishes. You are so inconsiderate.

SOFT: I feel overwhelmed when the dishes pile up after dinner. I need us to find a system for sharing this task.

HARSH: You always spend money without telling me. You are irresponsible.

SOFT: I feel anxious when I see unexpected charges. I need us to have a quick check-in before purchases over \$50.

HARSH: You care more about your phone than me.

SOFT: I feel disconnected when we are both on our phones during dinner. I would love to have device-free meals together.

Practice: Write Your Own Softened Startups

Issue 1: _____

I feel _____

about _____

and I need _____

Issue 2: _____
I feel _____
about _____
and I need _____

Issue 3: _____
I feel _____
about _____
and I need _____

The Time-Out Protocol

When emotions flood during an argument (heart rate above 100 BPM), productive communication becomes physiologically impossible. The time-out protocol prevents damage:

- Step 1: Either partner can call a time-out (use agreed signal or word)
- Step 2: Separate for a minimum of 20 minutes (this is physiological, not optional)
- Step 3: During the break, do something calming (walk, breathe, listen to music)
- Step 4: Do NOT rehearse arguments or build your case during the break
- Step 5: Return at the agreed time and resume with softened startups

Our time-out signal/word: _____
Minimum break duration we agree to: _____ minutes
What I will do during breaks: _____

The Compromise Worksheet

Use this worksheet when you have a disagreement that needs resolution:

Conflict Resolution Worksheet #1

The issue: _____

Partner 1's position: _____

What I can be flexible on: _____
What I cannot compromise on: _____

Partner 2's position: _____

What I can be flexible on: _____
What I cannot compromise on: _____

Our compromise: _____

Review date (to check if this is working): _____

Conflict Resolution Worksheet #2

The issue: _____

Partner 1's position: _____

What I can be flexible on: _____

What I cannot compromise on: _____

Partner 2's position: _____

What I can be flexible on: _____

What I cannot compromise on: _____

Our compromise: _____

Review date (to check if this is working): _____

Conflict Resolution Worksheet #3

The issue: _____

Partner 1's position: _____

What I can be flexible on: _____

What I cannot compromise on: _____

Partner 2's position: _____

What I can be flexible on: _____

What I cannot compromise on: _____

Our compromise: _____

Review date (to check if this is working): _____

Conflict Resolution Worksheet #4

The issue: _____

Partner 1's position: _____

What I can be flexible on: _____

What I cannot compromise on: _____

Partner 2's position: _____

What I can be flexible on: _____

What I cannot compromise on: _____

Our compromise: _____

Review date (to check if this is working): _____

Conflict Resolution Worksheet #5

The issue: _____

Partner 1's position: _____

What I can be flexible on: _____

What I cannot compromise on: _____

Partner 2's position: _____

What I can be flexible on: _____

What I cannot compromise on: _____

Our compromise: _____

Review date (to check if this is working): _____

Repair Attempts

Repair attempts are things you say or do during conflict to de-escalate tension.

Successful couples make repair attempts AND their partners accept them. Practice these:

- I am sorry. That came out wrong. Let me try again.
- I can see this is really important to you.
- You are making a good point. I had not thought of it that way.
- Can we start over? I do not like how this conversation is going.
- I love you. Even when we disagree, I am on your team.
- Let me make sure I understand what you are saying.
- I think we are both getting flooded. Can we take a break?
- What do you need from me right now?
- I appreciate you telling me how you feel.
- You are right about that part. I should not have done that.

Conflict Patterns Awareness

Track your conflicts for 4 weeks to identify patterns:

Conflict Log #1

Date: _____ Time: _____

Topic: _____

Who raised it: ☐ Me ☐ Partner

Startup style: ☐ Soft ☐ Harsh

Four Horsemen present: ☐ Criticism ☐ Contempt ☐ Defensiveness ☐ Stonewalling

Did we take a time-out? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Repair attempts made: ☐ Yes ☐ No Accepted? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Resolution reached: ☐ Yes ☐ Partial ☐ No

How I felt after: _____

What I would do differently: _____

Conflict Log #2

Date: _____ Time: _____

Topic: _____

Who raised it: ☐ Me ☐ Partner

Startup style: ☐ Soft ☐ Harsh

Four Horsemen present: ☐ Criticism ☐ Contempt ☐ Defensiveness ☐ Stonewalling

Did we take a time-out? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Repair attempts made: ☐ Yes ☐ No Accepted? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Resolution reached: ☐ Yes ☐ Partial ☐ No

How I felt after: _____

What I would do differently: _____

Conflict Log #3

Date: _____ Time: _____

Topic: _____

Who raised it: ☐ Me ☐ Partner

Startup style: ☐ Soft ☐ Harsh

Four Horsemen present: ☐ Criticism ☐ Contempt ☐ Defensiveness ☐ Stonewalling

Did we take a time-out? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Repair attempts made: ☐ Yes ☐ No Accepted? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Resolution reached: ☐ Yes ☐ Partial ☐ No

How I felt after: _____

What I would do differently: _____

Conflict Log #4

Date: _____ Time: _____

Topic: _____

Who raised it: ☐ Me ☐ Partner

Startup style: ☐ Soft ☐ Harsh

Four Horsemen present: ☐ Criticism ☐ Contempt ☐ Defensiveness ☐ Stonewalling

Did we take a time-out? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Repair attempts made: ☐ Yes ☐ No Accepted? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Resolution reached: ☐ Yes ☐ Partial ☐ No

How I felt after: _____

What I would do differently: _____

Conflict Log #5

Date: _____ Time: _____

Topic: _____

Who raised it: ☐ Me ☐ Partner

Startup style: ☐ Soft ☐ Harsh

Four Horsemen present: ☐ Criticism ☐ Contempt ☐ Defensiveness ☐ Stonewalling

Did we take a time-out? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Repair attempts made: ☐ Yes ☐ No Accepted? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Resolution reached: ☐ Yes ☐ Partial ☐ No

How I felt after: _____

What I would do differently: _____

Conflict Log #6

Date: _____ Time: _____

Topic: _____

Who raised it: ☐ Me ☐ Partner

Startup style: ☐ Soft ☐ Harsh

Four Horsemen present: ☐ Criticism ☐ Contempt ☐ Defensiveness ☐ Stonewalling

Did we take a time-out? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Repair attempts made: ☐ Yes ☐ No Accepted? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Resolution reached: ☐ Yes ☐ Partial ☐ No

How I felt after: _____

What I would do differently: _____

Conflict Log #7

Date: _____ Time: _____

Topic: _____

Who raised it: ☐ Me ☐ Partner

Startup style: ☐ Soft ☐ Harsh

Four Horsemen present: ☐ Criticism ☐ Contempt ☐ Defensiveness ☐ Stonewalling

Did we take a time-out? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Repair attempts made: ☐ Yes ☐ No Accepted? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Resolution reached: ☐ Yes ☐ Partial ☐ No

How I felt after: _____

What I would do differently: _____

Conflict Log #8

Date: _____ Time: _____

Topic: _____

Who raised it: ☐ Me ☐ Partner

Startup style: ☐ Soft ☐ Harsh

Four Horsemen present: ☐ Criticism ☐ Contempt ☐ Defensiveness ☐ Stonewalling

Did we take a time-out? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Repair attempts made: ☐ Yes ☐ No Accepted? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Resolution reached: ☐ Yes ☐ Partial ☐ No

How I felt after: _____

What I would do differently: _____

Apology Language Worksheet

Different people receive apologies differently. Understanding your partner's apology language helps you repair effectively:

The 5 Apology Languages:

- 1. Expressing regret: I am sorry. I feel terrible about this.
- 2. Accepting responsibility: I was wrong. There is no excuse.
- 3. Making restitution: What can I do to make this right?
- 4. Genuine repentance: I will change this behavior. Here is my plan.
- 5. Requesting forgiveness: Will you forgive me? I value our relationship.

My primary apology language (what I need to hear): _____

My partner's primary apology language: _____

Practice writing apologies in your partner's language:

For a recent situation: _____

YOUR ACTION ITEMS - Chapter 3

-
- [] Practice writing softened startups for current issues
 - [] Establish your time-out protocol together
 - [] Use the compromise worksheet for one current disagreement
 - [] Memorize 3 repair attempts to use during arguments
 - [] Notice when you use harsh startups and catch yourself
 - [] Agree to accept each other's repair attempts going forward
 - [] Complete 4 weeks of conflict logging
 - [] Identify each other's apology language

CHAPTER 4: DEEP CONNECTION EXERCISES

Building Emotional Intimacy

Emotional intimacy is built through vulnerability, curiosity, and shared experiences. Over time, couples often stop asking deep questions because they assume they already know everything about each other. But people change and grow, and maintaining curiosity about your partner keeps the relationship alive and deepening.

These 36 questions are inspired by research showing that mutual vulnerability fosters closeness. Take turns asking and answering. Give each question the time it deserves. No rushing, no judging, and no phones.

36 Questions to Deepen Your Connection

Set 1: Getting Reacquainted (Light)

1. What is something you have always wanted to try but have been afraid to?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

2. If you could have dinner with anyone in history, who would it be and why?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

3. What does your perfect ordinary Tuesday look like 5 years from now?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

4. What is your happiest memory from our relationship so far?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

5. If you received a million dollars tomorrow, what would you do with it?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

6. What is something you admire about me that you have never told me?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

7. What did you dream of becoming when you were a child?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

8. What is the most adventurous thing you have ever done?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

9. If you could live anywhere in the world for a year, where would you choose?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

10. What is something small that brings you joy every day?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

11. What song reminds you of us or of falling in love?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

12. What is something you want to learn or get better at this year?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

Set 2: Going Deeper (Medium)

13. What is your biggest fear about our future together?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

14. When do you feel most loved by me? What specifically do I do?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

15. What is something from your childhood that still affects you today?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

16. If you could change one thing about how you were raised, what would it be?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

17. What do you think is my greatest strength? My biggest challenge?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

18. What does home mean to you? Not a place, but a feeling.

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

19. When was the last time you cried? What was it about?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

20. What is something you need more of in our relationship?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

21. What is a belief you held strongly that has changed over the years?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

22. If our relationship had a theme song right now, what would it be?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

23. What is one thing you wish you could tell your younger self?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

24. How do you want to be remembered by the people you love?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

Set 3: Deepest Vulnerability (Intense)

25. What is something you have been afraid to tell me?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

26. What is your deepest insecurity in our relationship?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

27. What do you think is the biggest challenge we face as a couple?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

28. If I could understand one thing about you better, what would it be?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

29. What does forgiveness look like to you? Is there anything you need to forgive?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

30. What is the most painful experience you have been through and how did it change you?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

31. What do you need from me during your hardest moments?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

32. What is one thing about our intimacy (emotional or physical) you wish was different?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

33. If we could not fail, what would we build or create together?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

34. What legacy do you want us to leave as a couple?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

35. What are you most grateful for about us?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

36. What do you want to say to me that you have been holding back?

Partner 1 answer: _____

Partner 2 answer: _____

YOUR ACTION ITEMS - Chapter 4

-
- [] Complete Set 1 together this week (one evening, no distractions)
 - [] Complete Set 2 the following week
 - [] Complete Set 3 when you both feel safe and connected
 - [] Listen without judgment, even if answers surprise you
 - [] Thank your partner for their vulnerability after each session
 - [] Revisit these questions in 6 months - answers will have changed

BONUS: UNDERSTANDING LOVE LANGUAGES

The 5 Love Languages

Dr. Gary Chapman's research shows that people give and receive love in five primary ways. Understanding your partner's love language means you can express love in the way that actually makes them FEEL loved, rather than expressing it in the way that makes sense to you.

1. Words of Affirmation

Verbal compliments, words of appreciation, encouragement, and hearing I love you. What to say: I am proud of you. You look amazing. I appreciate how hard you work for our family. Thank you for always being there.

2. Quality Time

Undivided attention, being fully present, shared activities, meaningful conversations. What to do: Put the phone away. Make eye contact. Plan activities together. Have device-free meals.

3. Physical Touch

Holding hands, hugs, kisses, cuddling, physical closeness, sexual intimacy. What to do: Reach for their hand. Kiss hello and goodbye. Sit close. Give spontaneous hugs.

4. Acts of Service

Doing things to make life easier: cooking, cleaning, running errands, taking care of tasks without being asked. What to do: Fill the car with gas. Make dinner. Handle a task they dislike.

5. Receiving Gifts

Thoughtful presents, visual symbols of love, remembering special occasions, surprise tokens of affection. What to do: Pick up their favorite coffee. Remember anniversaries. Give flowers randomly.

Love Language Assessment

Rate how much each expression of love matters to you (1=least, 5=most):

Partner 1: _____

- ___ Words of Affirmation (compliments, encouragement, verbal love)
- ___ Quality Time (undivided attention, shared activities)
- ___ Physical Touch (holding hands, hugs, kisses, closeness)
- ___ Acts of Service (doing helpful things, easing burdens)
- ___ Receiving Gifts (thoughtful presents, tokens of love)

My primary love language: _____

My secondary love language: _____

Partner 2: _____

___ Words of Affirmation (compliments, encouragement, verbal love)

___ Quality Time (undivided attention, shared activities)

___ Physical Touch (holding hands, hugs, kisses, closeness)

___ Acts of Service (doing helpful things, easing burdens)

___ Receiving Gifts (thoughtful presents, tokens of love)

My primary love language: _____

My secondary love language: _____

Speaking Your Partner's Love Language

Now that you know each other's love languages, brainstorm specific actions:

5 ways I will speak Partner 1's love language this week:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

5 ways I will speak Partner 2's love language this week:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

Love Language Weekly Tracker

Week 1

Actions I took in partner's language: _____

Actions partner took in my language: _____

Did I feel loved this week? (1-10): _____

Did partner feel loved? (1-10): _____

What worked best: _____

What I will try next week: _____

Week 2

Actions I took in partner's language: _____

Actions partner took in my language: _____

Did I feel loved this week? (1-10): _____

Did partner feel loved? (1-10): _____

What worked best: _____

What I will try next week: _____

Week 3

Actions I took in partner's language: ____

Actions partner took in my language: ____

Did I feel loved this week? (1-10): ____

Did partner feel loved? (1-10): ____

What worked best: _____

What I will try next week: _____

Week 4

Actions I took in partner's language: ____

Actions partner took in my language: ____

Did I feel loved this week? (1-10): ____

Did partner feel loved? (1-10): ____

What worked best: _____

What I will try next week: _____

CHAPTER 5: HARD CONVERSATIONS SCRIPTS

Navigating Difficult Topics

Every relationship has topics that feel scary to bring up: money, intimacy, in-laws, parenting differences, unmet needs, or personal boundaries. The longer you avoid these conversations, the bigger and more explosive they become. These scripts give you a starting framework for approaching tough topics with grace.

Remember: You do not have to resolve everything in one conversation. The goal of the first conversation is to be heard and to hear your partner. Solutions come in follow-up conversations after both people feel understood.

Script 1: Talking About Money

Opening: I would like to have an honest conversation about our finances. This is not about blaming anyone. I want us to be a team when it comes to money.

Questions to discuss together:

- What was money like in your family growing up?
- What does financial security mean to you?
- Are there spending habits either of us has that concern the other?
- What are our shared financial goals for this year? In 5 years?
- How should we handle individual vs. shared spending?

Our agreements about money:

Script 2: Talking About Intimacy

Opening: Our physical and emotional connection is really important to me. I want to make sure we are both feeling fulfilled and connected. Can we talk openly about this?

Questions to discuss together:

- On a scale of 1-10, how satisfied are you with our physical intimacy?
- What makes you feel most desired and attractive?
- Is there anything you would like more of? Less of?
- What barriers do we face to connection (stress, schedule, energy)?
- How can we prioritize time for intimacy?

Our agreements about intimacy:

Script 3: Talking About Family Boundaries

Opening: I love both of our families, and I want to make sure we are setting boundaries that protect our relationship. Can we talk about what feels comfortable for both of us?

Questions to discuss together:

- How often should we visit or host each family?
- What topics are off-limits for family members to weigh in on?
- How do we handle it when a family member oversteps?
- Who communicates boundaries to which family?
- How do we support each other during family conflicts?

Our family boundary agreements:

Script 4: Talking About Division of Labor

Opening: I want us both to feel like household responsibilities are shared fairly. This is not about keeping score - it is about both of us feeling like a team. Can we figure this out together?

Exercise: List who currently does each task and discuss if it feels fair:

- Cooking: _____
- Dishes: _____
- Laundry: _____
- Grocery shopping: _____
- Cleaning bathrooms: _____
- Vacuuming/mopping: _____
- Yard work: _____
- Bills/finances: _____
- Pet care: _____
- Scheduling/appointments: _____

Changes we are making:

Script 5: Talking About Unmet Needs

Opening: There is something I have been needing that I want to share with you. I know you love me and would want to know. This is not a criticism - it is an invitation for us to grow closer.

Template:

I have been feeling: _____

What I need more of: _____

What that would look like specifically: _____

How it would make me feel: _____

Partner's response:

What I heard you say: _____

I am willing to: _____

I need from you in return: _____

Script 6: Talking About Future Goals

Opening: I want to make sure we are building a life that excites us both. Can we dream together about what we want our future to look like?

Questions to discuss together:

- Where do we want to be living in 5 years? 10 years?
- Do we want children? If so, when? How many?
- What are our career aspirations? How do we support each other?
- What role does religion or spirituality play in our future?
- How do we envision retirement? What will we do together?
- What adventures or experiences are on our shared bucket list?

Our shared vision for the future:

1 year: _____

5 years: _____

10 years: _____

Lifetime dreams: _____

Conversation Preparation Worksheet

Use this worksheet before any difficult conversation:

Topic I need to discuss: _____

Why this matters to me: _____

My feelings about this: _____

What I need from this conversation: _____

My softened startup: _____

What my partner might feel hearing this: _____

How can I show empathy for their perspective: _____

Best time/place for this conversation: _____

If things get heated, I will: _____

Ideal outcome: _____

Am I willing to compromise? What is flexible: _____

YOUR ACTION ITEMS - Chapter 5

- ☐ Choose one hard conversation you have been avoiding
- ☐ Use the appropriate script to prepare your opener
- ☐ Schedule a time to have the conversation (not spontaneously)
- ☐ Use softened startup and active listening during the conversation
- ☐ Write down your agreements
- ☐ Schedule a follow-up conversation to check on progress

CHAPTER 6: WEEKLY & MONTHLY RITUALS

The Power of Relationship Rituals

Happy couples do not leave their connection to chance. They build regular rituals into their lives that ensure they stay emotionally connected regardless of how busy, stressful, or routine life becomes. These are not grand gestures but consistent, small practices that compound into deep intimacy over time.

Daily Connection Rituals (5-10 minutes)

1. The 6-Second Kiss

Research shows that a kiss lasting at least 6 seconds is long enough to create a moment of genuine connection and release bonding hormones. Make this your hello and goodbye ritual.

2. Highs, Lows, and Gratitudes

Each evening, share: one high point of your day, one low point, and one thing you are grateful for about your partner. This takes 5 minutes and maintains emotional awareness.

3. The Stress-Reducing Conversation

Spend 10-15 minutes at the end of each day talking about stresses OUTSIDE the relationship (work, friends, family). The listener's job is only to be supportive, not to give advice.

4. Goodnight Ritual

Go to bed at the same time at least a few nights per week. This is when many couples have their best conversations and feel most connected.

Weekly Rituals

The Weekly Check-In (30 minutes)

Schedule 30 minutes each week (same time) to discuss your relationship directly. This prevents issues from building up and ensures you stay proactive about connection.

Our weekly check-in time: _____ Day: _____

Weekly Check-In Agenda:

- 1. Appreciations: Each share 3 things you appreciated about your partner this week
- 2. Logistics: Calendar review, upcoming events, coordination
- 3. Issues: Any small things that need addressing? (use softened startups)
- 4. Fun: Plan something enjoyable for the coming week
- 5. Intimacy: Check in on physical and emotional connection

WEEKLY CHECK-IN #1

Date: _____

Appreciations (share 3 each)

Partner 1 appreciates:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Partner 2 appreciates:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Relationship Temperature Check

How connected did we feel this week? (1-10)

Partner 1: ____ Partner 2: ____

How well did we communicate? (1-10)

Partner 1: ____ Partner 2: ____

How supported did I feel? (1-10)

Partner 1: ____ Partner 2: ____

Highlights & Challenges

Best moment together this week: _____

A challenge we faced: _____

How we handled it: _____

Logistics & Calendar

Upcoming events: _____

Coordination needed: _____

Decisions to make together: _____

Issues to Address (use softened startup)

Issue 1: _____

I feel: _____ about: _____ and I need: _____

Agreement: _____

Issue 2: _____

I feel: _____ about: _____ and I need: _____

Agreement: _____

Fun & Connection Plans

Date night this week: _____

Daily ritual we will practice: _____

Something new we will try: _____

Goals for Next Week

As a couple we will: _____

I personally commit to: _____

What would make next week a 10: _____

WEEKLY CHECK-IN #2

Date: _____

Appreciations (share 3 each)

Partner 1 appreciates:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Partner 2 appreciates:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Relationship Temperature Check

How connected did we feel this week? (1-10)

Partner 1: ____ Partner 2: ____

How well did we communicate? (1-10)

Partner 1: ____ Partner 2: ____

How supported did I feel? (1-10)

Partner 1: ____ Partner 2: ____

Highlights & Challenges

Best moment together this week: _____

A challenge we faced: _____

How we handled it: _____

Logistics & Calendar

Upcoming events: _____

Coordination needed: _____

Decisions to make together: _____

Issues to Address (use softened startup)

Issue 1: _____

I feel: _____ about: _____ and I need: _____

Agreement: _____

Issue 2: _____

I feel: _____ about: _____ and I need: _____

Agreement: _____

Fun & Connection Plans

Date night this week: _____

Daily ritual we will practice: _____

Something new we will try: _____

Goals for Next Week

As a couple we will: _____

I personally commit to: _____

What would make next week a 10: _____

WEEKLY CHECK-IN #3

Date: _____

Appreciations (share 3 each)

Partner 1 appreciates:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Partner 2 appreciates:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Relationship Temperature Check

How connected did we feel this week? (1-10)

Partner 1: ____ Partner 2: ____

How well did we communicate? (1-10)

Partner 1: ____ Partner 2: ____

How supported did I feel? (1-10)

Partner 1: ____ Partner 2: ____

Highlights & Challenges

Best moment together this week: _____

A challenge we faced: _____

How we handled it: _____

Logistics & Calendar

Upcoming events: _____

Coordination needed: _____

Decisions to make together: _____

Issues to Address (use softened startup)

Issue 1: _____

I feel: _____ about: _____ and I need: _____

Agreement: _____

Issue 2: _____

I feel: _____ about: _____ and I need: _____

Agreement: _____

Fun & Connection Plans

Date night this week: _____

Daily ritual we will practice: _____

Something new we will try: _____

Goals for Next Week

As a couple we will: _____

I personally commit to: _____

What would make next week a 10: _____

WEEKLY CHECK-IN #4

Date: _____

Appreciations (share 3 each)

Partner 1 appreciates:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Partner 2 appreciates:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Relationship Temperature Check

How connected did we feel this week? (1-10)

Partner 1: ____ Partner 2: ____

How well did we communicate? (1-10)

Partner 1: ____ Partner 2: ____

How supported did I feel? (1-10)

Partner 1: ____ Partner 2: ____

Highlights & Challenges

Best moment together this week: _____

A challenge we faced: _____

How we handled it: _____

Logistics & Calendar

Upcoming events: _____

Coordination needed: _____

Decisions to make together: _____

Issues to Address (use softened startup)

Issue 1: _____

I feel: _____ about: _____ and I need: _____

Agreement: _____

Issue 2: _____

I feel: _____ about: _____ and I need: _____

Agreement: _____

Fun & Connection Plans

Date night this week: _____

Daily ritual we will practice: _____

Something new we will try: _____

Goals for Next Week

As a couple we will: _____

I personally commit to: _____

What would make next week a 10: _____

WEEKLY CHECK-IN #5

Date: _____

Appreciations (share 3 each)

Partner 1 appreciates:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Partner 2 appreciates:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Relationship Temperature Check

How connected did we feel this week? (1-10)

Partner 1: ____ Partner 2: ____

How well did we communicate? (1-10)

Partner 1: ____ Partner 2: ____

How supported did I feel? (1-10)

Partner 1: ____ Partner 2: ____

Highlights & Challenges

Best moment together this week: _____

A challenge we faced: _____

How we handled it: _____

Logistics & Calendar

Upcoming events: _____

Coordination needed: _____

Decisions to make together: _____

Issues to Address (use softened startup)

Issue 1: _____

I feel: _____ about: _____ and I need: _____

Agreement: _____

Issue 2: _____

I feel: _____ about: _____ and I need: _____

Agreement: _____

Fun & Connection Plans

Date night this week: _____

Daily ritual we will practice: _____

Something new we will try: _____

Goals for Next Week

As a couple we will: _____

I personally commit to: _____

What would make next week a 10: _____

WEEKLY CHECK-IN #6

Date: _____

Appreciations (share 3 each)

Partner 1 appreciates:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Partner 2 appreciates:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Relationship Temperature Check

How connected did we feel this week? (1-10)

Partner 1: ____ Partner 2: ____

How well did we communicate? (1-10)

Partner 1: ____ Partner 2: ____

How supported did I feel? (1-10)

Partner 1: ____ Partner 2: ____

Highlights & Challenges

Best moment together this week: _____

A challenge we faced: _____

How we handled it: _____

Logistics & Calendar

Upcoming events: _____

Coordination needed: _____

Decisions to make together: _____

Issues to Address (use softened startup)

Issue 1: _____

I feel: _____ about: _____ and I need: _____

Agreement: _____

Issue 2: _____

I feel: _____ about: _____ and I need: _____

Agreement: _____

Fun & Connection Plans

Date night this week: _____

Daily ritual we will practice: _____

Something new we will try: _____

Goals for Next Week

As a couple we will: _____

I personally commit to: _____

What would make next week a 10: _____

WEEKLY CHECK-IN #7

Date: _____

Appreciations (share 3 each)

Partner 1 appreciates:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Partner 2 appreciates:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Relationship Temperature Check

How connected did we feel this week? (1-10)

Partner 1: ____ Partner 2: ____

How well did we communicate? (1-10)

Partner 1: ____ Partner 2: ____

How supported did I feel? (1-10)

Partner 1: ____ Partner 2: ____

Highlights & Challenges

Best moment together this week: _____

A challenge we faced: _____

How we handled it: _____

Logistics & Calendar

Upcoming events: _____

Coordination needed: _____

Decisions to make together: _____

Issues to Address (use softened startup)

Issue 1: _____

I feel: _____ about: _____ and I need: _____

Agreement: _____

Issue 2: _____

I feel: _____ about: _____ and I need: _____

Agreement: _____

Fun & Connection Plans

Date night this week: _____

Daily ritual we will practice: _____

Something new we will try: _____

Goals for Next Week

As a couple we will: _____

I personally commit to: _____

What would make next week a 10: _____

WEEKLY CHECK-IN #8

Date: _____

Appreciations (share 3 each)

Partner 1 appreciates:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Partner 2 appreciates:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Relationship Temperature Check

How connected did we feel this week? (1-10)

Partner 1: ____ Partner 2: ____

How well did we communicate? (1-10)

Partner 1: ____ Partner 2: ____

How supported did I feel? (1-10)

Partner 1: ____ Partner 2: ____

Highlights & Challenges

Best moment together this week: _____

A challenge we faced: _____

How we handled it: _____

Logistics & Calendar

Upcoming events: _____

Coordination needed: _____

Decisions to make together: _____

Issues to Address (use softened startup)

Issue 1: _____

I feel: _____ about: _____ and I need: _____

Agreement: _____

Issue 2: _____

I feel: _____ about: _____ and I need: _____

Agreement: _____

Fun & Connection Plans

Date night this week: _____

Daily ritual we will practice: _____

Something new we will try: _____

Goals for Next Week

As a couple we will: _____

I personally commit to: _____

What would make next week a 10: _____

Monthly Rituals

Monthly State of the Union

Once a month, have a deeper conversation about the overall direction of your relationship.

Discuss goals, dreams, challenges, and growth areas.

Monthly Date Night

Commit to at least one intentional date night per month. Alternate who plans it. Make it something that creates new shared experiences.

YOUR ACTION ITEMS - Chapter 6

-
- ☐ Choose 2 daily rituals to start this week
 - ☐ Schedule your weekly check-in time
 - ☐ Complete your first weekly check-in using the template
 - ☐ Plan your next monthly date night
 - ☐ Commit to these rituals for 30 days before evaluating

CHAPTER 7: DATE NIGHT PLANNING

Why Regular Dates Matter

Couples who have regular date nights report higher relationship satisfaction, better communication, increased intimacy, and lower divorce rates. Date nights work because they create dedicated time for connection away from the routines, responsibilities, and distractions of daily life.

The key to great date nights: novelty. Research shows that couples who try new things together experience increases in relationship satisfaction that mimic the excitement of early dating. Break out of the dinner-and-movie routine and explore together.

52 Date Night Ideas (One for Every Week)

Adventure & Outdoors

- 1. Take a sunset hike at a trail you have never been to
- 2. Rent kayaks or paddleboards for a morning on the water
- 3. Go stargazing at a dark sky location with blankets and hot chocolate
- 4. Take a road trip to a town within 2 hours that you have never visited
- 5. Go rock climbing at an indoor gym together
- 6. Bike ride along a scenic route with a picnic stop
- 7. Visit a botanical garden or nature reserve
- 8. Go camping in your backyard (fire pit, s'mores, sleeping bags)
- 9. Take a sunrise walk on the beach
- 10. Try geocaching in your city
- 11. Go berry picking or visit a farm in season
- 12. Explore a new neighborhood on foot together
- 13. Take a ferry ride somewhere

Creative & Learning

- 14. Take a pottery or ceramics class together
- 15. Attend a cooking class (Thai, Italian, sushi-making)
- 16. Visit a museum and discuss your favorite pieces over coffee after
- 17. Take a dance class (salsa, swing, ballroom)
- 18. Paint and sip night (at home or at a studio)
- 19. Attend a live theater performance or local play
- 20. Take a photography walk with a theme (doors, shadows, color red)
- 21. Build something together (furniture, garden bed, LEGO set)
- 22. Write letters to your future selves to open in 5 years
- 23. Visit a bookstore and each pick a book for the other
- 24. Take a language class together
- 25. Attend a wine or whiskey tasting

- 26. Go to an open mic night or comedy show

Cozy & At-Home

- 27. Build a blanket fort and watch childhood movies
- 28. Cook a fancy multi-course dinner together with candles
- 29. Have a game night (board games, card games, video games)
- 30. Create a DIY spa night (face masks, massage, bubble bath)
- 31. Do a puzzle together with jazz music and wine
- 32. Have a themed movie marathon (trilogy, decade, director)
- 33. Recreate your first date at home
- 34. Build a vision board together for your next year
- 35. Have a fondue night (cheese AND chocolate)
- 36. Indoor picnic on the living room floor
- 37. Read to each other from a book you both choose
- 38. Do a couples workout video together
- 39. Try a new recipe from a cuisine neither of you has cooked before

Social & Community

- 40. Double date with another couple you admire
- 41. Volunteer together at a local charity or food bank
- 42. Attend a local festival, fair, or market
- 43. Take a group class or workshop
- 44. Host a themed dinner party together
- 45. Go to a sporting event (even a minor league game)
- 46. Attend a concert or live music event
- 47. Visit a farmers market and cook what you find
- 48. Take a neighborhood walking tour
- 49. Go to a trivia night at a local bar
- 50. Visit an escape room with friends
- 51. Attend a community event (parade, outdoor movie, fireworks)
- 52. Explore a flea market or antique shop together

Date Night Planner

Date Night #1

Date: _____ Planned by: _____

Activity: _____

Location: _____

Budget: \$ _____

What we loved about it: _____

Connection rating (1-10): _____

Something new I learned about my partner: _____

Would we do this again? [] Yes [] No

Date Night #2

Date: _____ Planned by: _____

Activity: _____

Location: _____

Budget: \$ _____

What we loved about it: _____

Connection rating (1-10): ____

Something new I learned about my partner: _____

Would we do this again? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Date Night #3

Date: _____ Planned by: _____

Activity: _____

Location: _____

Budget: \$ _____

What we loved about it: _____

Connection rating (1-10): ____

Something new I learned about my partner: _____

Would we do this again? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Date Night #4

Date: _____ Planned by: _____

Activity: _____

Location: _____

Budget: \$ _____

What we loved about it: _____

Connection rating (1-10): ____

Something new I learned about my partner: _____

Would we do this again? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Date Night #5

Date: _____ Planned by: _____

Activity: _____

Location: _____

Budget: \$ _____

What we loved about it: _____

Connection rating (1-10): ____

Something new I learned about my partner: _____

Would we do this again? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Date Night #6

Date: _____ Planned by: _____

Activity: _____

Location: _____

Budget: \$ _____

What we loved about it: _____

Connection rating (1-10): ____

Something new I learned about my partner: _____

Would we do this again? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Date Night #7

Date: _____ Planned by: _____

Activity: _____

Location: _____

Budget: \$ _____

What we loved about it: _____

Connection rating (1-10): ____

Something new I learned about my partner: _____

Would we do this again? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Date Night #8

Date: _____ Planned by: _____

Activity: _____

Location: _____

Budget: \$ _____

What we loved about it: _____

Connection rating (1-10): ____

Something new I learned about my partner: _____

Would we do this again? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Date Night #9

Date: _____ Planned by: _____

Activity: _____

Location: _____

Budget: \$ _____

What we loved about it: _____

Connection rating (1-10): ____

Something new I learned about my partner: _____

Would we do this again? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Date Night #10

Date: _____ Planned by: _____

Activity: _____

Location: _____

Budget: \$ _____

What we loved about it: _____

Connection rating (1-10): ____

Something new I learned about my partner: _____

Would we do this again? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Date Night #11

Date: _____ Planned by: _____

Activity: _____

Location: _____

Budget: \$ _____

What we loved about it: _____

Connection rating (1-10): ____

Something new I learned about my partner: _____

Would we do this again? ☐ Yes ☐ No

Date Night #12

Date: _____ Planned by: _____

Activity: _____

Location: _____

Budget: \$ _____

What we loved about it: _____

Connection rating (1-10): ____

Something new I learned about my partner: _____

Would we do this again? ☐ Yes ☐ No

YOUR ACTION ITEMS - Chapter 7

- ☐ Schedule your next date night right now
- ☐ Each partner stars 5 ideas from the list above
- ☐ Alternate who plans date night each time
- ☐ Keep phones put away during the entire date
- ☐ Try at least one brand-new activity together this month
- ☐ Make date night non-negotiable (protect it like a meeting)

CHAPTER 8: REBUILDING TRUST

When Trust Has Been Broken

Trust is the foundation of every healthy relationship. When it is broken, whether through dishonesty, betrayal, broken promises, or emotional unavailability, the relationship enters a critical period. Rebuilding trust is possible but requires consistent effort, patience, accountability, and genuine willingness to change from both partners.

This chapter provides a framework for the difficult work of trust repair. If the breach was severe (infidelity, addiction, abuse), please work with a licensed couples therapist alongside this workbook.

Understanding Trust

Trust is not a single thing. It is built from multiple components:

- RELIABILITY: You do what you say you will do, consistently
- HONESTY: You tell the truth, even when it is uncomfortable
- VULNERABILITY: You share your inner world authentically
- SAFETY: Your partner feels physically and emotionally safe with you
- LOYALTY: You protect the relationship from outside threats
- ACCOUNTABILITY: You take responsibility when you make mistakes

Trust Assessment

Rate each area of trust from 1 (completely broken) to 10 (fully intact):

Partner 1 rates trust in Partner 2:

Reliability: ____ Honesty: ____ Vulnerability: ____
Safety: ____ Loyalty: ____ Accountability: ____
Overall trust level: ____ / 10

Partner 2 rates trust in Partner 1:

Reliability: ____ Honesty: ____ Vulnerability: ____
Safety: ____ Loyalty: ____ Accountability: ____
Overall trust level: ____ / 10

The Trust Rebuilding Process

Phase 1: Acknowledgment (Weeks 1-4)

The person who broke trust must fully acknowledge what happened, take responsibility without excuses, and demonstrate genuine remorse. The hurt partner needs space to express their pain without being shut down.

What happened (write it honestly): _____

How it affected my partner: _____

What I take responsibility for: _____

Phase 2: Transparency (Weeks 4-12)

Rebuilding trust requires radical transparency. The person who broke trust willingly offers more information, more access, and more check-ins than normal.

Specific transparency commitments I am making:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

Phase 3: Consistency (Months 3-12)

Trust is rebuilt through hundreds of small consistent actions over time. There are no shortcuts. The hurt partner watches for alignment between words and actions.

Monthly trust check-in:

Month 1: Trust level (1-10): ____	Evidence of change: _____
Month 2: Trust level (1-10): ____	Evidence of change: _____
Month 3: Trust level (1-10): ____	Evidence of change: _____
Month 4: Trust level (1-10): ____	Evidence of change: _____
Month 5: Trust level (1-10): ____	Evidence of change: _____
Month 6: Trust level (1-10): ____	Evidence of change: _____

Phase 4: Forgiveness and New Beginning (12+ months)

Forgiveness is not forgetting. It is choosing to release resentment and move forward. It cannot be rushed or demanded. It happens when the hurt partner sees consistent change and feels safe again.

Am I ready to forgive? Reflection:

Daily Trust-Building Actions

Small daily actions that rebuild trust over time:

- Follow through on every promise, no matter how small
- Be where you say you will be, when you say you will be there

- Share information proactively rather than waiting to be asked
- Be honest about small things (this builds credibility for big things)
- Check in emotionally: How are you doing? How are we doing?
- Accept your partner's feelings without getting defensive
- Show patience when your partner needs reassurance
- Prioritize the relationship visibly
- Be consistent even when you think no one is watching
- Celebrate small milestones in the rebuilding process

Trust Rebuilding Journal

Use this journal weekly to track your trust rebuilding progress:

Trust Journal Entry #1

Date: _____ Week #: _____

Trust level this week (1-10): _____

Trust-building actions I took this week:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Moments I felt trust growing:

Moments that felt difficult:

What my partner did that helped:

What I need more of: _____

My commitment for next week: _____

Trust Journal Entry #2

Date: _____ Week #: _____

Trust level this week (1-10): _____

Trust-building actions I took this week:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Moments I felt trust growing:

Moments that felt difficult:

What my partner did that helped:

What I need more of: _____

My commitment for next week: _____

Trust Journal Entry #3

Date: _____ Week #: _____

Trust level this week (1-10): _____

Trust-building actions I took this week:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Moments I felt trust growing:

Moments that felt difficult:

What my partner did that helped:

What I need more of: _____

My commitment for next week: _____

Trust Journal Entry #4

Date: _____ Week #: _____

Trust level this week (1-10): _____

Trust-building actions I took this week:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Moments I felt trust growing:

Moments that felt difficult:

What my partner did that helped:

What I need more of: _____

My commitment for next week: _____

Trust Journal Entry #5

Date: _____ Week #: _____

Trust level this week (1-10): _____

Trust-building actions I took this week:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Moments I felt trust growing:

Moments that felt difficult:

What my partner did that helped:

What I need more of: _____

My commitment for next week: _____

Trust Journal Entry #6

Date: _____ Week #: _____

Trust level this week (1-10): _____

Trust-building actions I took this week:

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

Moments I felt trust growing:

Moments that felt difficult:

What my partner did that helped:

What I need more of: _____

My commitment for next week: _____

Trust Journal Entry #7

Date: _____ Week #: _____

Trust level this week (1-10): _____

Trust-building actions I took this week:

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

Moments I felt trust growing:

Moments that felt difficult:

What my partner did that helped:

What I need more of: _____

My commitment for next week: _____

Trust Journal Entry #8

Date: _____ Week #: _____

Trust level this week (1-10): _____

Trust-building actions I took this week:

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

Moments I felt trust growing:

Moments that felt difficult:

What my partner did that helped:

What I need more of: _____

My commitment for next week: _____

YOUR ACTION ITEMS - Chapter 8

-
- ☐ Complete the trust assessment together honestly
 - ☐ Identify which phase of trust rebuilding you are in
 - ☐ Write specific transparency commitments
 - ☐ Schedule monthly trust check-ins
 - ☐ Practice daily trust-building actions consistently
 - ☐ Consider working with a couples therapist for support

NEXT STEPS

Congratulations on investing in your relationship by working through this workbook. The fact that you are here means you care deeply about your connection and are willing to put in the work. That commitment is the most important ingredient in a thriving relationship.

Your Ongoing Practice

- Continue weekly check-ins (they prevent issues from building up)
- Keep having regular date nights (protect this time)
- Practice active listening daily
- Use softened startups whenever raising an issue
- Revisit the 36 questions every 6 months (your answers will evolve)
- Celebrate your progress and growth as a couple

When to Seek Professional Help

Consider couples therapy if:

- The same issues keep recurring without resolution
- Communication frequently escalates to yelling or silence
- There has been infidelity or betrayal
- One or both partners feel emotionally disconnected
- You are considering separation
- There is any form of abuse (physical, emotional, financial)

By Daniel Tesfamariam

Your relationship is worth fighting for. Keep communicating, keep connecting, keep choosing each other.